AI-generated deepfake videos they said violated "their personality and intellectual property rights", seeking Rs 4 crore in damages. Suniel Shetty, too, had to seek legal protection for his personality rights after a deepfake image of him and his grandchild went viral. Akshay Kumar had a whole AI-generated film trailer featuring him as Maharishi Valmiki doing the rounds on social media. "I want to clarify that all such videos are fake," Kumar wrote in an online post. "In today's time, when misleading content is being produced at great speed through manipulative AI, I sincerely request media houses to verify and report only after authenticating the information."

Beyond these violations, there is also growing anxiety around AI taking over jobs. Hollywood was all astir recently when news broke that talent management agencies were courting AI-generated actress Tilly Norwood. "I see AI not as a replacement for people, but as a new tool, a new paintbrush," said Eline Van der Velden, Norwood's creator and an actor herself. "Just as animation, puppetry or CGI opened fresh possibilities without taking away from live acting, AI offers another way to imagine and build stories."

As technology evolves, so do insecurities, as the lines between digital and human creativity blur. "There may come a time when we would not need actors and just create them," Varun Dhawan said at the trailer launch of *Sunny Sanskari Ki Tulsi Kumari*, while highlighting the need for laws to protect artists' rights.

It's for this reason that Dipankar Mukherjee is betting big on the adoption of FAIMOUS, touted as the world's first ethical celeb cloning platform. It allows celebs or celeb management firms to create verifiable, traceable and authorised clones of their voices and faces, and then lease it out to any agency, brand or filmmaker for a limited tenure. "Any asset generated comes to the celeb for consent," says Mukherjee. "A unique digital identity helps track down unauthorised use."

Change is Inevitable

Not everyone views AI with scepticism. Many in the industry recognise the need to adapt and upskill to remain relevant. Even the writers of *Saiyaara*, the biggest romantic blockbuster of 2025, took to ChatGPT for ideas when stuck on an ending. It's a different thing that ultimately they relied on their own instinct and settled for a happier one.

Among AI's most enthusiastic advocates is Vijay Subramaniam, founder and CEO of Collective Artists Network (CAN). In July 2024, CAN acquired the Bengaluru-based AI-driven influencer marketing platform Galleri5 to expand his business. On its rolls now are AI-generated influencers, including Kabir Manja, a millionaire who has turned to easy living; Radhika Subramaniam, a software engineer who left her day job to explore India; and Kavya Mehra, an uptown fashionista. "These are characters and stories we are building, and brands are connecting with them," boasts Subramaniam. That's not all, there's also an AI-generated spiritual rock band called Trilok.



"AI is the most democratic technology ever.... Soon kids will be able to create content that was once the realm of big budget studios....at a tiny tiny tiny fraction of your budgets"

SHEKHAR KAPUR
Filmmaker, on X

But Subramanian isn't done yet. He has started a content vertical called Historyverse, which will use AI extensively to churn out stories rooted in Indian mythology and history. Its debut AI feature, *Chiranjeevi Hanuman*, created in collaboration with Abunduntia Entertainment, has a team of 50-plus engineers from Galleri5 working with cultural scholars and literary experts to bring the legend of Hanuman to life in less than a year. "This majestic project is built on efficiency, speed and creative experimentation, showing how technology when combined with culture and history can expand the way stories are brought to life in theatres," says Subramaniam.

Filmmakers Anurag Kashyap and Vikramaditya Motwane didn't exactly share the enthusiasm. "So much for looking after and representing the interests of creators," Kashyap wrote on Instagram. "End of the day, all these agencies are only interested in making money off you and since they choose turkeys after turkeys for you and you're not making enough for them, they are going all AI." Motwane, who directed *CTRL*, a Netflix film exploring the dangers of artificial intelligence on human intelligence, also voiced his criticism: "And so it begins... Who TF [the f**k] needs writers and directors when it's 'Made in AI'."

Subramaniam dismisses the detractors and insists that some things will never change. "Stardom will never go away. Touch and feel will never go away," he says. "AI will have orchestrators who are creators. I believe it will give birth to more efficient writers and for those on the video side, editing will become easier. It's not replacement, it's enhancement. Time is the only commodity you cannot control and AI will save you time." His tribe is convinced AI in filmmaking is not a question of if, but when. "There's no escaping it," Subramaniam predicts. "This is the new internet. Get in with the party or be left out. You cannot fight it." ■